

Business

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US, consumer prices

% increase on a year earlier



Source: Bureau of Labour Statistics

產生影像說明

The Federal Reserve raised its benchmark interest rate by 0.25 percentage points, to 3.75-4%. It was the first increase since July 2023. All 12 rate-setters backed the move. Inflation remains stubbornly high, fuelled by tariffs and soaring energy

prices. The decision is Kevin Warsh's first change in monetary policy since becoming chairman in May. An angry Donald Trump responded by demanding that the Fed cut rates to 1%.

Bond yields rose after the Fed signalled that most policymakers expect more interest-rate increases this year. Yields had already been climbing as higher oil prices stoked fears of persistent inflation; earlier the yield on ten-year Treasuries reached its highest level since 2007.

Sam Altman of OpenAI, Elon Musk of xAI and Dario Amodei of Anthropic called for a slowdown in the race to build superhuman artificial intelligence, amid fears that models could escape human control. The unusual show of unity comes as Anthropic prepares an IPO that could value the company at \$2trn. The safety scare could delay the listing or dent its valuation; Mr Altman said OpenAI would not go public this year. Mr Trump dismissed the warnings, arguing that beating China in AI mattered most.

Meanwhile, Microsoft published a draft "code of conduct" designed to keep its AI models under human control. The document—which states that "people matter more than AI"—says the technology should not imitate consciousness, nor assist with the development of weapons.

America's Senate blocked legislation to establish clearer rules for cryptocurrencies. The Clarity Act would have written the Trump administration's crypto-friendly policies into law, making it harder for a future administration to impose tougher rules. Democrats opposed the bill over concerns about Mr Trump's own crypto interests.

Building trouble

China's property slump dragged on in August. Prices of new homes fell by 0.1% from July, the 16th consecutive monthly decline, and by 3% from a year earlier. Prices in the wealthiest cities rose slightly, while those in the rest continued to fall. The prolonged housing bust is depressing household confidence and consumption, leaving China reliant on exports to sustain economic growth.

India's trade deficit narrowed unexpectedly in August, from \$32bn to \$27bn. Exports surged by 26% year on year, because of strong demand from America and Europe, while imports rose by 14%. The smaller gap may offer some relief to the rupee, one of Asia's worst-performing currencies this year. But soaring oil prices pose a threat: India imports nearly 90% of its crude.

Accenture agreed to pay \$25m to settle allegations by America's government that it discriminated in hiring and promotions by considering applicants' race and sex to meet diversity targets. The consultancy denied wrongdoing. Mr Trump has sought to stamp out diversity, equity and inclusion programmes. Deloitte and IBM have paid \$21.5m and \$17m respectively to settle similar investigations this year.

Aliko Dangote, Africa's richest man, listed his refinery business on Nigeria's stock exchange in what is expected to be Africa's biggest-ever IPO. Valued at around \$49bn, the company hopes to raise \$1.6bn by October. With a minimum purchase of just ten shares, it is targeting 10m retail investors; Mr Dangote has dubbed it "the people's IPO".

L'Oréal overtook LVMH to become France's most valuable listed company, the first time since 2017 that a non-luxury firm has held the crown. The cosmetics giant is worth €203bn (\$233bn), against LVMH's €201bn. Its rise reflects the "lipstick effect": cash-strapped consumers can still afford small indulgences, even as they shun pricey handbags.

Carlos Ghosn, a former boss of Renault-Nissan, in exile in Lebanon after fleeing charges of financial misconduct in Japan, went on trial for corruption in Paris. Prosecutors allege that a €300,000-a-year contract for legal advice he awarded Rachida Dati, a former French culture minister and then member of the European Parliament, concealed payments for lobbying. Both deny wrongdoing.

High steaks

Mr Trump's efforts to make burgers cheaper before the midterms are not going to plan. Ground-beef prices hit a record-high in August, up 8% year on year. Mr Trump has blamed meatpackers and tried to beef up supply by easing tariffs on imports. But years of drought and high feed costs have shrunk America's cattle herd by nearly a tenth since 2020, pushing up prices.

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